

An idea whose time has gone

The Commonwealth Games might have been a useful platform once for countries that had little hope in world championships or the Olympics. But now even the best available athletes **stay away** when it interferes with their training.

Suresh Menon

After every edition of the Commonwealth Games, two streams of thought emerge, or more correctly, gush forth. One speaks of unity and spirit and all things sport is expected to provide, and the other harps on the irrelevance of the Games. I am among the harpers. Two questions follow: will the Commonwealth Games survive? And, more importantly, should the Commonwealth Games survive?

The chief executive of the Glasgow Games has said that they have the potential to survive for "another 100 years." Good news or bad news, depending on which side of the debate you fall on.

Ahmedabad are the hosts for the next edition, so it might sound anti-national and unpatriotic to keep harping. Also, India get to introduce a couple of games, probably kabaddi and kho kho, maybe even yoga and hope to increase their medal tally. And that will seem justification enough. India are bound to put up a strong show as hosts, thus keeping the Games alive for a period.

At any rate, in the absence of the U.S., Russia, China, Japan, Germany and other sporting superpowers, India are guaranteed a finish in the top 10, even in the top four, as in Glasgow. It gives some of their not-quite-world-class athletes a chance to win a medal or two and earn free lifetime railway passes or whatever.

India are pushing to host the 2036 Olympics (probably in Ahmedabad again, if the current political dispensation continues, or in New Delhi if they don't; sporting India



doesn't seem to extend beyond the Vindhyas). The Commonwealth Games are seen as dress rehearsal.

Multi-sport events are expensive. Durban, Kuala Lumpur, Cardiff, Calgary, Adelaide have all withdrawn over the years citing the exorbitant cost. Victoria in Australia was officially declared the venue for a scaled down 2026 Games before they withdrew too, leaving Glasgow to hold the baby. But the 380 million-dollar (Australian) fine they had to pay was a useful contribution to Glasgow.

The Commonwealth is a collection of some 50-odd countries, most of them former British colonies. It speaks well for both the conquerors

and the conquered that their relationship is such that they can exist as a grouping under the Crown. It began as the British Empire Games, and the least the Crown can do is to give it a name that is less redolent of the ills of colonialism. Perhaps India can take the lead in the renaming.

Glasgow had 10 events, down from the 19 previously. India will probably restore some, if not all of them. It will be a government show, but that is the only way the Commonwealth Games are likely to work.

It might have been a useful platform once for countries that had little hope in world championships or the Olympics. It was inaugurated in 1930 when few of the countries were yet to gain their Independence from the British. Now even the best available athletes stay away when it interferes with their training. The Commonwealth Games is an idea whose time has gone.